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Study Notes

Communication – Meaning, types, Role and Barriers

Introduction

Communication is the process of exchanging information, ideas, thoughts, feelings, emotions, etc. between individuals, through a medium/channel. Communication plays an important role in the smooth and effective functioning of any organization.

A breakdown in the communication channel leads to an inefficient flow in information. For example, if employees are unaware of what the organization expects of them, this could cause employees to become suspicious of motives and changes in the company. This could negatively affect productivity in the workplace. If productivity decreases, eventually this will harm the organization as a whole. Therefore, in order for an organization to run well, a good manager should be able to effectively communicate to employees what is expected of them, make sure they are fully aware of company policies and inform them of any upcoming changes. This should help to optimize employee productivity and ensure that the organization runs smoothly.

Meaning and Process

- Communication requires at least two parties – sender of information (who sends the message) and receiver of information (who gives feedback).
- Two-way process; includes feedback
- A communication is effective or successful, when it produces the desired result
- Essence of management; necessary to perform functions of management

The **process of communication** would start with sender and ends with the feedback from the receiver which completes the communication loop.

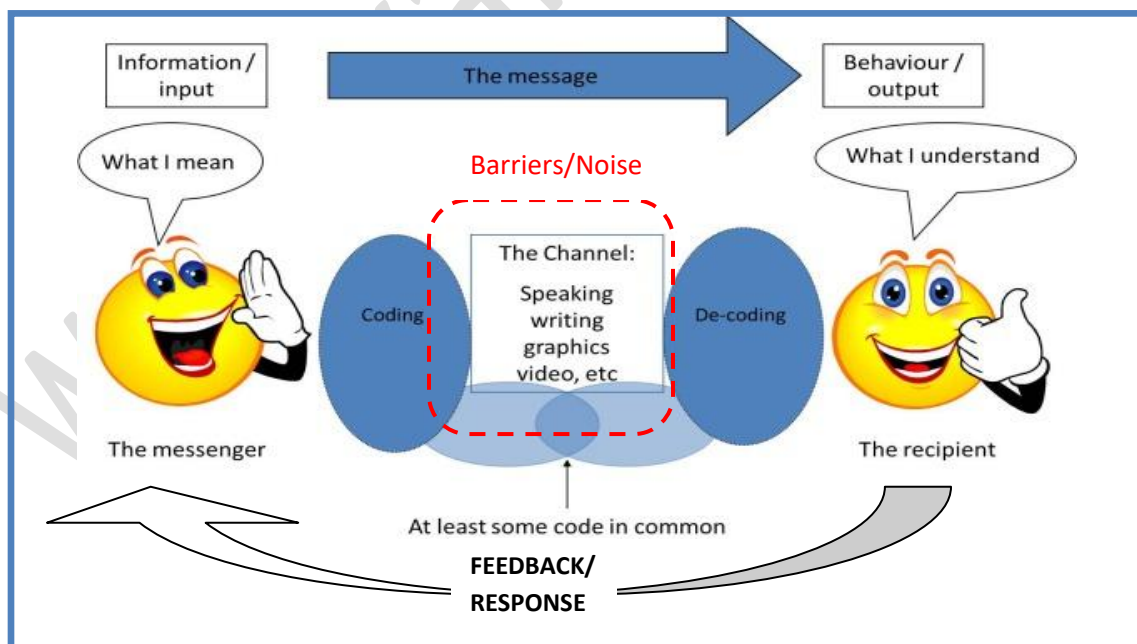


Figure: Communication loop

- **Messenger/Sender** – the person who wants to communicate, has an idea, information, feeling, etc. that he wants to share

- **Coding/encoding** – preparing the content of the message by use of words, symbols, etc.
- **Channel/Medium** – the means used to transmit the message like speaking face-to-face, over a phone, through letter, email, etc.
- **Barriers/Noise** - the various obstacles or hurdles that arise in between of an effective communication leading to misinterpretation by the receiver
- **Receiver** – the person for whom the message is intended/targeted
- **Decoding** - The message is decoded/understood by the receiver
- **Feedback** – the receiver responds to the sender after decoding the message

Communication Channels/Medium

Communication channels refer to the way the information flows within the organization. There are many different types of communication channels available for managers to use like face-to-face communication, mobile technology, electronic bulletin boards, fax machines and video conferencing.

As organizations grow, managers cannot rely on face-to-face communication alone to get their message across. A challenge that managers face today is to determine what type of communication channel to use in order to carry out effective communication.

In the current scenario of 'work from home', video conferencing has gained importance as a medium of communication for many organisations.

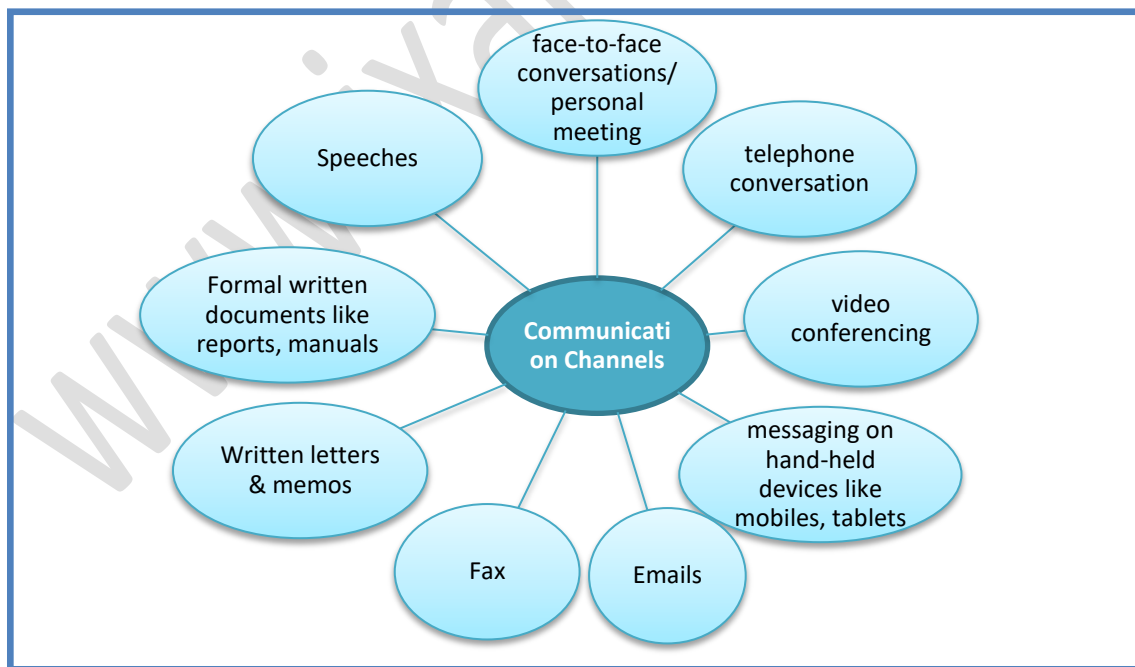


Figure: Communication channels

Effective communication

Communication is said to be effective when both the sender and the receiver of the information understand the message in same aspect.

When the sender sends a message, he/she has an intended meaning of what he/she wants to communicate. The receiver has his/her own interpretation of what has been communicated. When the intended message is understood by the receiver in same manner, the communication becomes effective and leads to the desired result. The medium of communication chosen here by him/her also affects the quality and impact of communication.

***For example,** a manager tells his subordinate to complete the project report started by the manager soon. The subordinate starts working on the project report given by his manager without a set timeline. The manager was expecting the project report in 3 days and was disappointed to know that the subordinate had not completed it by then. Here the communication was not effective, as the urgency of the project report was not understood by the subordinate.*

This communication could have been made effective by following certain rules. There are **7 C's of effective communication** which are applicable to both written as well as oral communication. These are as follows:

1. **Completeness** - The communication must be complete. It should convey all facts required by the audience. Complete communication develops and enhances reputation of an organization.
 - It is cost saving as no crucial information is missing and no additional cost is incurred in conveying extra message.
 - It leaves no questions in the mind of receiver.
2. **Conciseness** - Conciseness means communicating what you want to convey in least possible words without forgoing the other C's of communication.
 - It is both time-saving as well as cost-saving.
 - It underlines and highlights the main message as it avoids using excessive and needless words.
3. **Consideration** - Effective communication must take the audience into consideration, i.e., the audience's viewpoints, background, mind-set, education level, etc.
 - Empathize with the audience and exhibit interest in the audience. This will stimulate a positive reaction from the audience.
4. **Clarity** - Clarity in communication makes understanding easier.
 - Clear message makes use of exact, appropriate and concrete words. For example, in the above case, rather than saying that the project report is needed soon, the manager could have given an exact date for completion of the report.

5. **Concreteness** - Concreteness strengthens the confidence as it is backed by logical statements, evidence, facts and figures etc.
 - It makes use of words that are clear and that build the reputation.
 - Concrete messages are not misinterpreted.
6. **Courtesy** - The sender of the message should be sincerely polite, judicious, reflective and enthusiastic.
 - Courtesy implies taking into consideration both viewpoints as well as feelings of the receiver of the message.
 - Courteous message is positive and focused on the audience.
7. **Correctness** - Correctness in communication implies that there are no grammatical errors in communication. The message is exact, correct and well-timed.
 - Correct message has greater impact on the audience/readers.

Awareness of these 7 C's of communication makes you an effective communicator. The onus of clarification that the intended message has been received is on both the ends - sender and receiver

Completeness	•message should give complete information •message should provide all required facts and figures
Conciseness	•short and precise; to the point •avoid repetition, unnecessary details
Clarity	•clear message by using precise , familiar and easy words •emphasize on specific goals at a time
Correctness	•use of right level of language, gramatically correct •non-discriminatory language
Consideration	•consider the receiver's interest/intention •draft message by keeping in mind the target group
Courtesy	•positive and focussed; consider receiver's feelings •sincere, polite, judicious, unbiased message
Concreteness	•be specific, definite, image building words •avoid general and vague comments

Figure: 7 C's of Effective Communication

Formal and informal Communication

Companies need to be able to communicate effectively. This is especially true of large companies where personal interaction may not be practical. This is where formal communication comes into play.

Formal communication involves utilizing the formal communication channels of an organization. The flow of information is controlled and needs deliberate effort to be properly communicated. Formal communication follows a hierarchical structure and chain of command. Formal communication can move vertically in an organization. Information is collected and flows up to the top levels of management for review and decision making, while orders flow down from the top to the place where it will be implemented. For example, employees may be given a presentation from the human resources department on new policies and procedures. Formal communication can also flow horizontally across the organization.

Employees are bound to follow formal communication channels while performing their duties. Formal communication is considered effective as it is a timely and systematic flow of communication.

In comparison, **informal communication** refers to communication which is multi-dimensional. Informal communication moves freely within the organization and is not bound by pre-defined channels and communication routes. Informal communication is particularly quick. Informal communication is far more relational than formal communication and is by nature, a very natural form of communication as people interact with each other freely and can talk about a diverse range of topics, often extending outside of their work duties. Due to the inherent nature of informal communication, it moves a lot faster and does not have a paper trail.

Informal communication in the workplace is often called the 'grapevine' and generally begins with employees through social relations. In many cases informal communications can turn to formal communication if they are added into the formal communication information flow of a company. Informal communication is considered effective as employees can discuss work-related issues which saves the organization time and money. It also helps to build more productive and healthy relationships in the workforce.

The key difference between the two are:

Formal Communication	Informal /Grapevine
Based on formal organization structure relation of superior and subordinate	Based on inter personal relations between individuals in an organization
Systematic, structured and follows the organizational structure	Unsystematic and erratic and free flow of information
It is time consuming as follows the organization structure	It is quick as there are no line of commands to follow
Official and planned communication regarding work related matters	Unofficial, personal communication
Needed to achieve organizational objectives	Needed to fulfill social, interpersonal, affiliation needs of individuals
E.g. – email from superior, reports, performance appraisal, instructions for job, etc.	Conversations at office parties, rumours and gossips

Both formal and informal communication have their time and place in the workplace, and both are effective when used correctly. Communication also has a role to play in building a culture of work ethic.

Formal communication and Direction of Communication within Organizations

Some of the most important types of direction in formal communication are:

1. Downward
2. Upward
3. Horizontal or Lateral and
4. Diagonal or Cross-wise

The basic purpose of designing such communication is to connect various departments of an organisation and coordinating their functioning for achieving smooth functioning.

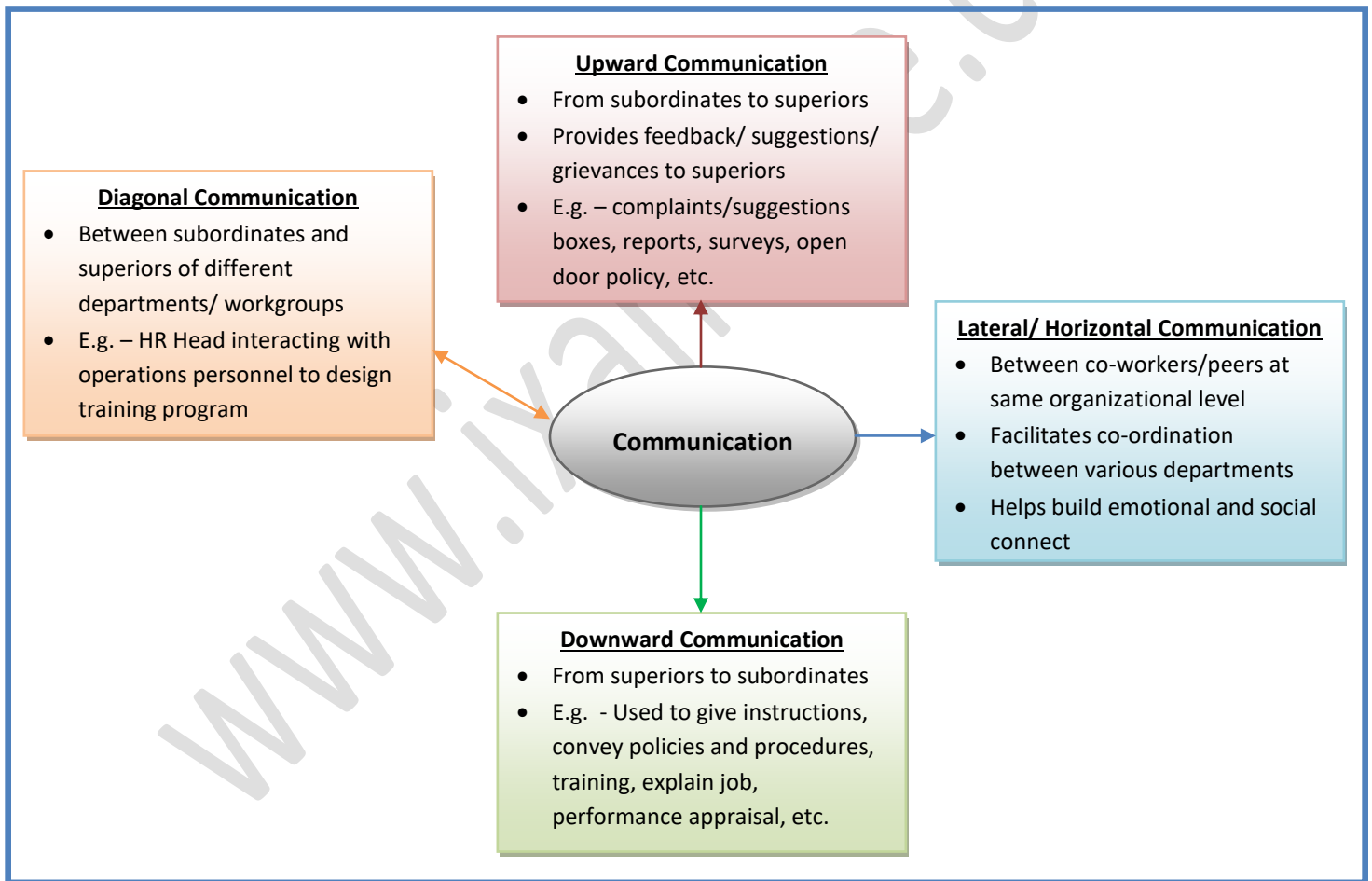


Figure: Formal communication flow directions

1. Downward communication: It is based on the assumption that the people working at higher levels have the authority to communicate to the people working at lower levels. Communication in the first place, flows downwards. This direction of communication strengthens the authoritarian structure of the organisation. This is also called Down Stream Communication. It is

the most common form of formal communication. Downward communication includes orders and instructions represented in oral or written format. Reports, emails, letters and manual communication are commonly used downward communication tools.

2. Upward communication: The function of upward communication is to send information, suggestions, complaints and grievances of the lower level workers to the managers above. It is, therefore, more participative in nature. Common forms of upward communication include (from employees to managers and above) reports, suggestions, requests, instructions and complaints.

3. Lateral or horizontal communication: Functional managers operating at the same level, in different departments, through their communication, present a good example of lateral communication. This type of communication can be seen taking place between persons operating at the same level or working under the same executive. Horizontal communication is slightly more fluid and dependent on cross-individual communication. Typical examples exist as communication between managers of different departments (HR, Marketing, Sales, etc.).

4. Diagonal or crosswise communication:

Diagonal or crosswise communication takes place when people working at the same level interact with those working at a higher or lower-level of organizational hierarchy and across the boundaries of their reporting relationships. This occurs when employees of different departments at different levels communicate with each other irrespective of the chain of command. Communication between a floor manager and a Sales team is a prime example of diagonal communication.

Verbal and Non-verbal Communication

Communication can be divided between verbal and non-verbal communication. **Verbal communication** is communication using words (spoken or written) that is understood by all parties to the communication. **Non-verbal communication** is sending a message without using words to convey meaning.

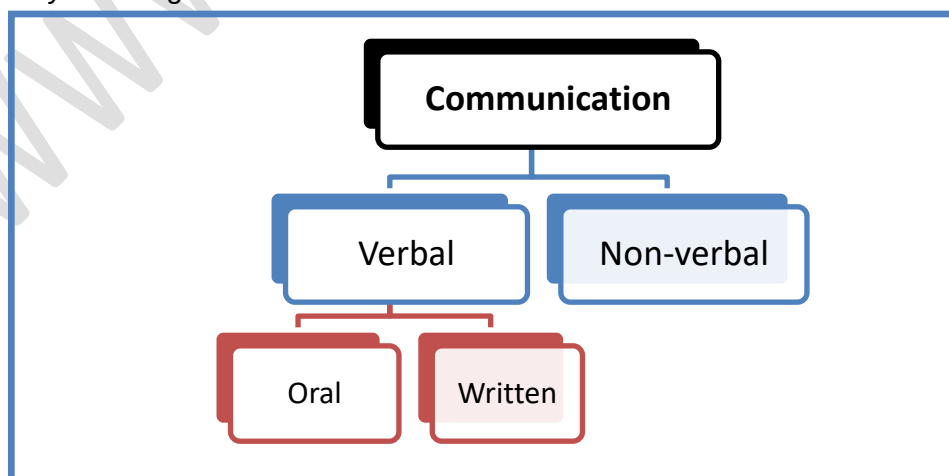


Figure: Verbal and non-verbal communication

Verbal Communication can take the form of oral (spoken) or written communication

- **Oral Communication:** This is the most common and primary mode of communication. It involves communication through spoken words which involves talking and listening. Oral communication can be the day-to-day chat that is informal and spontaneous and the formal ones which is useful when message is of temporary nature or of confidential nature or when direct interaction is required. Feedback is immediate. E.g. – face-to-face or over the phone conversation, lectures, conference, speech, presentation, discussion, video-calls.
- **Written Communication:** Communication through written words is known as written communication. It involves writing and reading, it is time consuming and rigid. However, it is authentic and credible as it is documented records. Usually formal, more structured and precise, it is useful when message is formal and fact based requiring recorded reference for future use. In this form of communication feedback is delayed E.g. – Letters, Memos, handbooks, manual reports etc.

Non-verbal Communication is communication of feelings, emotions, attitudes, and thoughts through body movements / gestures / eye contact, etc. The components of Non-verbal communication are:

- **Kinesics:** It is the study of facial expressions, postures & gestures. Did you know that while in Argentina to raise a fist in the air with knuckles pointing outwards expresses victory, in Lebanon, raising a closed fist is considered rude?
- **Oculesics:** It is the study of the role of eye contact in non-verbal communication. Did you know that in the first 90 sec - 4 min you decide that you are interested in someone or not. Studies reveal that 50% of this first impression comes from non-verbal communication which includes oculesics. Only 7% of comes from words - that we actually say.
- **Haptics:** It is the study of touching. Did you know that acceptable level of touching vary from one culture to another? In Thailand, touching someone's head may be considered as rude.
- **Proxemics:** It is the study of measurable distance between people as they interact. Did you know that the amount of personal space when having an informal conversation should vary between 18 inches - 4 feet while, the personal distance needed when speaking to a crowd of people should be around 10-12 feet?
- **Chronemics:** It is the study of use of time in non-verbal communication. Have you ever observed that while AN employee will not worry about running a few minutes late to meet a colleague, a manager who has a meeting with the CEO, a late arrival will be considered as a nonverbal cue that he / she does not give adequate respect to his superior?
- **Paralinguistics:** It is the study of variations in pitch, speed, volume, and pauses to convey meaning. Interestingly, when the speaker is making a presentation and is looking for a response, he will pause. However, when no response is desired, he will talk faster with minimal pause.

- **Physical Appearance:** Your physical appearance always contributes towards how people perceive you. Neatly combed hair, ironed clothes and a lively smile will always carry more weight than words.

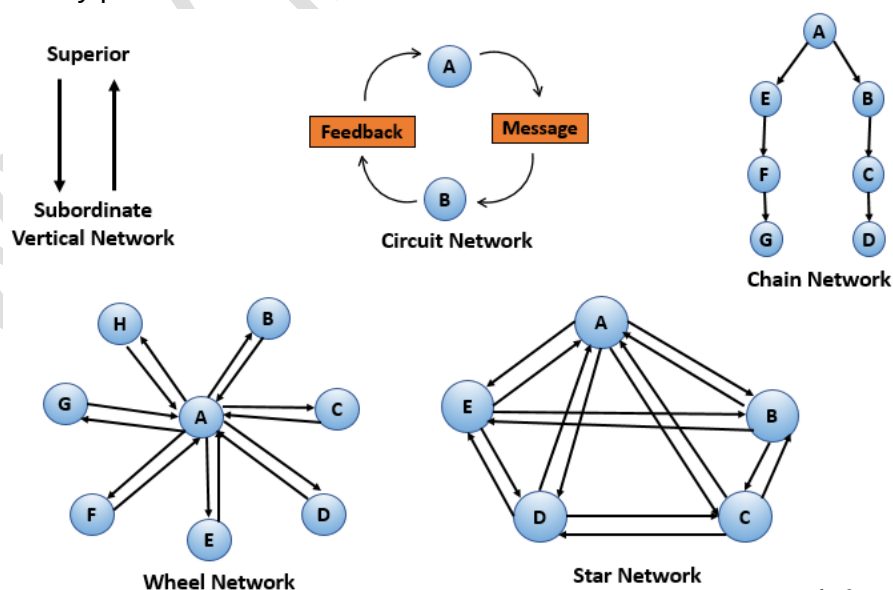
The key differences between verbal and non-verbal communication is as follows:

Verbal	Non-verbal
Communication through words, spoken or written	Communication through body movements, gestures, facial expressions, eye contact
Structured	Unstructured
Explicit and easy to comprehend	Not always explicit and difficult to understand
Can be used as evidence in future	No documentary evidence
Emphasis on "What we say"	Emphasis on "how we say it"
E.g. – discussion, telephone conversation, speech, interview, letter, email, memo, etc.	E.g. – facial expressions, body language, gestures, voice modulation, eye contact, posture, etc.

Communication Networks

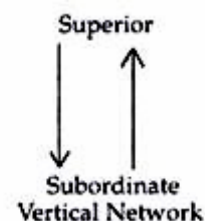
The pattern of contacts among the members of the organisation and flow of information among them is communication network. Network helps managers to establish contacts in different patterns through communication flows. The network depends upon the magnitude of the organisation, nature of communication channels in the organisation and the number of persons involved in the process.

There can be many patterns of communication network. Some of them include:



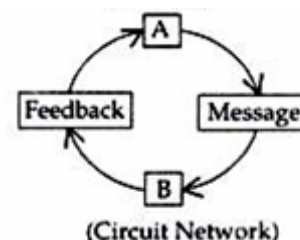
Vertical Network:

The vertical network is usually between the superior and subordinate and vice versa. It is two-way communication. The immediate feedback is possible in this type of communication network. It is formal network.



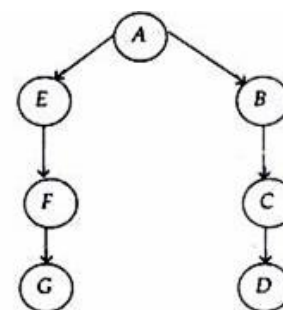
2. Circuit Network:

Under this network two persons communicate with each other. Say Mr. 'A' sends message to Mr. 'B'. After receiving message Mr. 'B' communicates the feedback message to Mr. 'A'. So communication takes the form of a circuit. Therefore it is known as circuit network. It is similar to vertical network but in circuit network 'A' and 'B' are not necessarily superior and subordinates.



3. Chain Network:

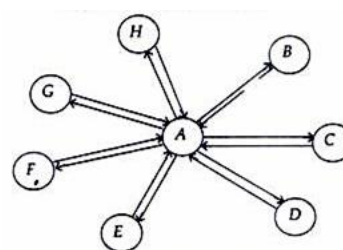
This network of communication follows the organisational hierarchy and chain of command. All subordinates receive commands or instructions from their superior. B, C, D and E, F, G are the subordinates to A in the organisational hierarchy and receive commands from 'A' which follows the way shown in the diagram.



Another form of this can be the **line network**.

4. Wheel Network:

Here all subordinates receive commands from one superior. This is highly centralized type of communication network where each subordinate receives commands or instructions from a single authority or superior 'A' and wants the immediate feedback.



5. Star or all-channel Network:

Under star communication network all members of the group communicate with each other and exchange information. This network is a must for group communication or where teamwork is involved. This network channel of communication is open to all members of the group. The members communicate with each other without hesitation.

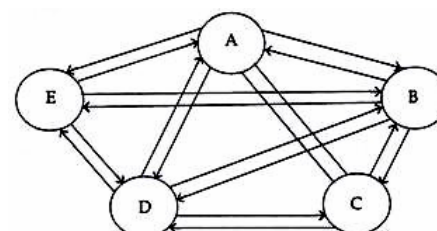


Fig. 15.6 Star Channel

The effectiveness of the above networks of communication channels depend upon their users i.e. the managers at all levels, their subordinates and other members of the organisation and above all the seriousness with which all these human resources make use of the facilities provided to them by the organisation to accomplish its objectives.

Barriers to Communication

Barriers to communication refers to any form of hindrance in the flow of communication or the various obstacles or hurdles that arise in between of an effective communication leading to misinterpretation by the receiver. Barriers can exist at any stage of communication process. When the message sent and received are not clear or not interpreted accurately or as intended, it can be due to some barriers in communication making the communication ineffective. It is therefore, important to understand the different types of barriers and remove them so as to increase the effectiveness of the communication.

Some of the common types of barriers to communication include:

- **Lack of planning:** Lack of planning is the cause of most failures. It refers to not structuring the communication, or choosing the right medium or timing of communication which leads to breakdown of effective communication.
- **Semantic or language Barriers** – The Semantic Barriers refers to the misunderstanding between the sender and receiver arising due to the different meanings of words, and other symbols used in the communication. The semantic barriers usually arise when the information is not in the simple language and contains those words or symbols that have multiple meanings. Too much use of technical jargons or faulty translations are other examples of semantic barriers.
- **Organizational Barrier:** Complex organization structure with too many levels leads to this barrier. Most of these barriers arise because of misinformation or lack of appropriate transparency available to the employees. It could include too many rules and policies, barriers arising due to hierarchical positions of power and status, information overload at some levels, etc.
- **Psychological/ Emotional/ Attitudinal and Personal:** Some people have stage fear, speech disorders, phobia, depression etc. All of these conditions are very difficult to manage sometimes and will most certainly limit the ease of communication. Personal biases, poor retention, distrust, fear of loss of authority (insecurity), lack of awareness or motivation are some other types of psychological barriers in communication.
- **Poor Listening and premature-evaluation** – this is also a type of psychological barrier. In case of poor listening, the communication is not decoded well by the receiver due to ignorance, pretense listening or selective listening. Active listening is important for the effective communication. In case of pre-mature evaluation, the receiver may jump to conclusion before the completion of full message which may lead to misunderstanding or incomplete understanding of the message.
- **Environmental or Physical barriers:** There are several environmental barriers in communication including external noise, time, physical distance, space, climate and

place. If the temperature is too high or too cold, then people can become agitated, frustrated and uncomfortable. The physical distance between two people will also affect the way that they are able to communicate with one another.

- **Technological barriers:** Barriers due to use of outdated technology or equipment, or proper infrastructure to support latest technology can post as barrier too. For example a presentation made on latest version of Microsoft fails to work in a meeting where the other person's laptop did not support it.
- **Cultural barriers** – barriers arising to differences in the culture of the parties to communication can also pose as barrier. These may be more prominent in global settings. For example, a handshake may not be a form of greeting in every culture.

Barriers - Reasons for breakdown in communication			
Category	Caused by	Examples	Solution
Semantic	Varied connotative meanings	• symbols with different meaning • badly expressed message • Unclear assumptions • faulty translations • Language difference	• Use simple common words to communicate • Avoid jargons • Draft message as per the audiences' level of understanding
Organisational	Structure of organization, diversity of culture	• Policies and rules • Complex organization structure with too many levels • Diverse cultural backgrounds of the individuals • Information overload • Time pressure – meeting tight deadlines	• Proper induction to familiarize with organizational policies • Simple organizational structure with manageable span of control • Avoid information overload by prioritizing the information to be shared • Flexible work environment
Psychological/ Emotional/ Attitudinal and Personal	Moods, attitudes, relationships, level of understanding and comprehension, motivation	• Difference in perception • Inattention • Poor retention • Premature evaluation • Distrust • Personal emotions and biases • Fear of loss of authority in superiors • Lack of awareness • Lack of motivation • Ignoring or the importance of communication	• Recruit right individuals as per job with required skill levels • Training programs • Encourage and practice active listening • Promote constructive feedback • Effective use of non-verbal communication
Environmental barriers	Physical disturbances in external environment	• Noise • Distance • Climate • Wrong choice of medium of communication • Technological malfunctions	• Eliminate noise levels • Choose the right medium of communication according to the message

Role of Information Technology

Benefits

- Improves productivity through an integrated telecommunications and computer systems
- Online training sessions from global experts possible
- Use of smart phones offers diverse set of skills on the go
- Faster communication
- Reduces costs
- videoconferencing connects geographically scattered individuals in real time thereby reducing travel expense
- digital files and back-up reduces paper work and storage issues

Risks

- Cyber security issues
- Data management is a huge responsibility and cost for the organisation
- An employee is always expected to be available for work which may reduce morale and motivation due to low work life balance
- Information overload